

THE ART OF RULING WELL

CONFUCIANISM, DAOISM, AND LEGALISM (476 BCE–221 BCE)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Law and philosophy

BEFORE

c. 1046–771 BCE Kings of the Western Zhou dynasty rule a feudal state, in which regional lords govern on their behalf.

771–476 BCE In the Spring and Autumn period, Zhou kings lose control as regional states fight among themselves. Bigger states conquer smaller ones until only seven are left: Chu, Han, Qi, Qin, Wei, Yan, and Zhao.

AFTER

221 BCE China is unified by the Qin dynasty (221–206 BCE), which imposes Legalism.

141 BCE The Han dynasty (206 BCE–220 CE) makes Confucianism the state philosophy and discredits Legalism.

During China's Warring States period (476–221 BCE), the country was divided into seven rival states, which were constantly at war with one another.

Chinese philosophers responded by developing three competing systems of belief: Confucianism, Daoism, and Legalism. Each took a very different approach to the role of government and law, and each had a lasting influence on Chinese history.

Confucianism

Philosopher Kong Fuzi (551–479 BCE), known as Confucius, looked to traditions to provide social stability. He stressed the importance of the ancient rites (*li*) performed

